HEARTLAND BLOSSOMS

India is growing because rural India is, building its future in myriad ways, though entrepreneurship, social change and, not to forget, cultural preservation. Three speakers from diverse fields came together to talk about this extraordinary transformation at the India Today Conclave—Ashok Kumar Sinha, additional director of the Bihar Museum; Shaikh Raziya, founder of Bastar Foods in Chhattisgarh; and Rajiv Marda, board member at the Dharm Sangh Vishwavidyalaya Sharmarth Nyas, Churu, Rajasthan—discussing how access to infrastructure has helped transform lives of the disadvantaged sections.

Through their experiences, they talked about how the institutions they represent have brought about change, be it by creating self-employment opportunities for the tribal youth in the LWE-affected villages of Bastar; or a modern-day gurukul which is providing a mix of modern and religious education free of cost; or the new Rs 800 crore Bihar Museum in Patna which is spreading awareness about art and laying the seeds of a new cultural awakening. In the process, they are also putting the spotlight on ideas and goods that for long have been on the sidelines—Sanskrit as a domain specialisation, or mahua, which has long been a go-to superfood for tribals in the hinterland and is now becoming a source of fascination for the West. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Businesses are driving social change, helping to wean away tribal youth from Naxalism**
- **Cultural preservation meets modernisation at institutions like Bihar Museum and DSVSN**
- **India's grassroots projects are getting global kudos**



HARDIK CHHABRA

Some 2,000 people come every day to visit the new Bihar Museum, including children from all over. We are not just about artefacts, we organise music and dance programmes, and special events for children
–Ashok Kumar Sinha
Addl Director, Bihar Museum

Our raw material comes from Bijapur, Sukma, Dantewada and Bastar, all Naxal-affected areas. But there is good road connectivity now, which has helped us. We now export to the US and Australia
–Shaikh Raziya
Founder, Bastar Foods

We blend ancient gurukul traditions with modern education. We bear all the expenses of our students, who are poor. Some of them, after becoming Shastri and Acharya, have settled in the US, UK and Singapore
–Rajiv Marda
Board Member, DSVSN, Churu